Reading Columns Aloud

Abstract. This short article is set in two columns below a title and an abstract that span the whole width of the page, so the reader can check the reading order.

Paragraph one opens the left column. Reading software has to follow the columns of a page, not the rows, or the sentences turn into nonsense when they are read aloud from left to right across the gutter.

Paragraph two continues the left column. Academic papers, newsletters and magazines often set their text in two columns because short lines are easier to read on a large page.

Figure 1. Columns on a page.

Paragraph three is still in the left column. A careful reader moves down one column to its end and then starts again at the top of the next column, and so should a voice.

Paragraph four begins the right column. When the order is right, the listener hears each paragraph in sequence and the argument of the article stays easy to follow.

2019	1,204	3.2%
2020	1,388	15.3%
2021	1,512	8.9%

Paragraph five sits in the right column. Small print at the bottom of the page, captions under figures and tables of numbers are best skipped while listening.

Paragraph six ends the right column. That is the end of the article, and the voice should stop here instead of reading the footnote below.

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1 This footnote explains a detail of the article and is printed in small type at the foot of the page.